

THE UNIVERSAL HOUSE OF JUSTICE

2000-07-18

To an individual believer dear bahá'í friend

1 has asked us to send you the following reply.

2 336-1. See no. 315, pp. 697-99.336.1

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337 .1

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339 75To your question "what do I have to think of the promotion of a bahá'í
340 democratization?" there is both a simple reply and a more complex one, and
341 the house of justice feels that it is desirable to approach the matter from
342 both points of view.

343 firstly, as a bahá'í who has given many decades of outstanding service in
344 your community, you understand that the bahá'í Administrative order is
345 an integral part of the revelation of bahá'u'lláh; it is a divinely conceived
346 system which, as the guardian explained in The Dispensation of Bahá'u'lláh,
347 "incorporates within its structure certain elements which are to be found in
348 each of the three recognized forms of secular government, without being
349 in any sense a mere replica of any one of them, and without introducing
350 within its machinery any of the objectionable features which they inherently possess.
it blends and harmonizes, as no government fashioned by

351 mortal hands has as yet accomplished, the salutary truths which each of these
systems undoubtedly contains without vitiating the integrity of those god-given verities on
which it is ultimately founded."

352 337-1

353 it is the continuing task of bahá'ís to increase their understanding of the
354 principles on which the Administrative order is founded, and to improve

355 the faithfulness with which they implement these principles in their actions. indeed
one of the specific needs of this period in the development of the

356 faith is the evolution of national and local bahá'í institutions. if, therefore,
357 by "the promotion of a bahá'í democratization" is meant the furthering of
358 an increasingly responsible participation in the work of the community by its
individual members, this is highly meritorious, and should be a con-tinual endeavor of b
ahá'í institutions.

359 That is the simple answer. however, if the intention is that the bahá'í
360 Administrative order should be altered to more closely accord with current
361 concepts of political democracy, a more complex series of issues arises. in

The Dispensation of Bahá'u'lláh

, Shoghi effendi lists evidences "of the non-

362 autocratic character of the bahá'í Administrative order and of its inclina-
363 tion to democratic methods in the administration of its affairs,"337-2 but this
364 does not justify a proposal to change the system which has been established
365 in the writings of bahá'u'lláh and 'Abdu'l-b ahá and in the elucidations of
366 Shoghi effendi. Such an effort, whether or not described as "the promotion
367 337-1. wob, pp. 152-53.

368 337-2. wob, p. 154. 337 .2

337 .3

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338 m e S a g e S f r o m T h e u n i v e r S a l h o u S e o f j u S T i c e

339 76of a bahá'í democratization," would be contrary to the clear teachings of
340 the faith. consideration of the various specific questions included in your
341 letter will help to clarify this distinction.

342 in the second paragraph of your letter you say that you understand that
343 the bahá'í world order is "at least 80%, a theocratic-aristocratic order."

344 inasmuch as the order of bahá'u'lláh is an integral part of the divine rev-
345 elation that he, as a manifestation of god, has given us, one could say that
346 this order is essentially theocratic, but inasmuch as it is entirely devoid of
347 any kind of clergy or priesthood, it is not at all a "theocracy" in the sense in
348 which the term is generally used and understood.

349 Similarly, the quality of aristocracy (rule by the best) as it appears in
350 the faith is in sharp contrast to what is generally understood by this term.
351 free from electioneering or such external pressures as those coming from
352 economic power or manipulation of the press, the believers seek to elect for
membership on their governing institutions those persons whom they regard as best
qualified for such office. The elected members are then responsible to god and to their
consciences, rather than to those who elect them. you are
353 undoubtedly familiar with Shoghi effendi's words in Bahá'í Administration
354 on the attitude and responsibility of members of Assemblies:

The duties of those whom the friends have freely and conscientiously

355 elected as their representatives are no less vital and binding than the
356 obligations of those who have chosen them. Their function is not to dictate, but to
consult, and consult not only among themselves, but

as much as possible with the friends whom they represent. They must

357 regard themselves in no other light but that of chosen instruments for a more efficient
and dignified presentation of the cause of god. They

should never be led to suppose that they are the central ornaments of

358 the body of the cause, intrinsically superior to others in capacity or
359 merit, and sole promoters of its teachings and principles. They should
360 approach their task with extreme humility, and endeavor, by their open-mindedness,
their high sense of justice and duty, their candor,
361 their modesty, their entire devotion to the welfare and interests of the

friends, the cause, and humanity, to win, not only the confidence

and the genuine support and respect of those whom they serve, but

also their esteem and real affection. They must, at all times, avoid

362 the spirit of exclusiveness, the atmosphere of secrecy, free themselves from a
domineering attitude, and banish all forms of prejudice and 337 .6

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338 2000–2001 • T h e T W e l v e m o n Th Pl a n

339 77passion from their deliberations. They should, within the limits of
340 wise discretion, take the friends into their confidence, acquaint them

with their plans, share with them their problems and anxieties, and

341 seek their advice and counsel. And, when they are called upon to arrive at a certain
decision, they should, after dispassionate, anxious and cordial consultation, turn to god in
prayer, and with earnestness and

342 conviction and courage record their vote and abide by the voice of the majority,
which we are told by our master to be the voice of truth,

343 never to be challenged, and always to be whole-heartedly enforced. To this voice the
friends must heartily respond, and regard it as the

only means that can ensure the protection and advancement of the

344 cause.

345 337-3

As already noted above, the way in which believers become members

346 of the elected institutions is democratic. it is, indeed, far more democratic

347 than the methods by which the members of most parliaments are elected. The bahá'í
electoral system is entirely free from the power and bargaining of

348 parties and factions, and from the manipulations of vested interests. each

349 voter is free to cast his or her ballot for whomever he or she chooses.

350 even in the best democracies nowadays the driving incentive in elections

351 is the wish of each politician to obtain power so as to be able to carry out the program
that he particularly favors—an election becomes a competition which the self-promoting
candidates either “win” or “lose.” The electorate

352 is treated as a mass to be swayed, by rhetoric and various forms of induce-

353 ment, to support one or other candidate. in the bahá'í system, however, the

354 voters are the active force and the motive which impels them is to choose

355 those individuals who are best suited to serve on the institution. The per-

356 sons elected are passive in the electoral process (except in their role as voters) and
accept election as an obligation to serve the community in response to the wish of the
electorate. in other words, the systems differ in their essential

357 spirit: one is a seeking for power, the other is an acceptance of responsibility for
service.

you mention several things which you describe as the most significant

358 democratic principles and values. Among them are transparency, account-

359 ability, freedom of the press and critical dialogue. here too, just as the

360 337-3. bA, p. 64.337 .8

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338 m e S a g e S f r o m T h e u n i v e r S a l h o u S e o f j u S T i c e

339 78spirit underlying the bahá'í system differs from that impelling most current

340 democratic systems, so do the methods of implementing these principles

341 and the attitude of those involved.

in general one can say that modern democracies have been established

342 as the outcome of attempts to limit the power of absolute monarchy, of

343 dictatorships, or of certain dominant classes. This may have come about

344 gradually through the centuries, or tumultuously by a series of revolutions.

345 Thus, even when democratic constitutions and structures have been estab-lished,
there remains a suspicion of authority as such, and a tension between the degree of freedom
accorded to individual citizens and the imposition of

346 sufficient public discipline to protect the weak against the selfish pursuits of

347 the strong among the citizenry. The operation of transparency, accountabil-ity,
freedom of the press and critical dialogue is thus imbued with a spirit

348 of partisanship that easily descends into the merciless invasion of personal

349 privacy, the dissemination of calumny, the exaggeration of mistrust, and the misuse
of the news media at the hands of vested interests. The reaction of those who attempt to
protect themselves against such distortions of the

350 system produces secretiveness, concealment of uncomfortable facts, and

351 reciprocal misuse of the media—in all, a perpetuation of disharmony in the social
fabric.

352 in contrast to these patterns bred by traditional antagonisms, the bahá'í

353 system is based upon the ideals of unity, harmony, justice, diversity and forbearance
in the building of a divinely conceived administrative struc-ture through a process of mutual
learning and discovery. As already noted,

354 the element of power-seeking is entirely absent. All members of a bahá'í

community, no matter what position they may temporarily occupy in the

355 administrative structure, are expected to regard themselves as involved in a learning
process, as they strive to understand and implement the laws and

356 principles of the faith. As part of this process, the Assemblies are encour-

357 aged to continually share their hopes and cares and the news of develop-

358 ments with the members of the community and to seek their views and support.
There are, of course, matters such as the personal problems of a

359 believer which he (or she) brings to his Assembly for advice, the amounts
360 of the contributions of individual believers to the fund, and so forth, in
361 relation to which the Assembly must observe strict confidentiality. As in any
362 just system of government the proper balance has to be sought and found
363 between extremes. in this connection, you will recall Shoghi effendi's state-

ment in Bahá'í Administration:337 .11

337 .12

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339 79let us also bear in mind that the keynote of the cause of god is

340 not dictatorial authority but humble fellowship, not arbitrary power,

but the spirit of frank and loving consultation. Nothing short of the

spirit of a true bahá'í can hope to reconcile the principles of mercy

341 and justice, of freedom and submission, of the sanctity of the right of the individual
and of self-surrender, of vigilance, discretion, and

prudence on the one hand, and fellowship, candor, and courage on

342 the other.

343 337-4

wherever one finds malfunctioning in a bahá'í community, it can be

344 traced to a failure to follow properly the laws, principles and methods laid

345 down in the writings. The overcoming of such shortcomings is part of the

346 learning process in which all bahá'ís are involved. The continual aim of the

347 institutions of the bahá'í community—whether it be through the operation

348 of summer schools and training institutes, through the development of the Nineteen
day feasts and National conventions, or through day-to-day in-

349 teraction among the friends—is to empower the individual believers so that

350 they will learn how to live their lives with increasing knowledge, wisdom, unity and
fruitfulness in conformity with the Teachings of b ahá'u'lláh.

further, in addition to the Spiritual Assemblies, the bahá'í Adminis-

351 trative order also contains the institutions of the continental boards of

counselors and their Auxiliary boards. Their endeavors, with the individuals, the community and the institutions, are intended to help maintain the true spirit of the faith, to counsel the governing institutions and to assist them to attain the high ideals set before them by bahá'u'lláh and the master. As the house of justice wrote in a letter dated 24 April 1972: "The existence of institutions of such exalted rank, comprising individuals who play such a vital role, who yet have no legislative, administrative or judicial authority, and are entirely devoid of priestly functions or the right to make authoritative interpretations, is a feature of bahá'í administration unparalleled in the

religions of the past."

337-5 The house of justice went on to comment that, only as the bahá'í community grows, and the believers are increasingly able to contemplate its administrative structure uninfluenced by concepts from past ages, will the vital interdependence of these two arms of the adminis-

337-4. bA, pp. 63-64.

337-5. muhj, no. 111.14.337 .12a

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message from The Universal House of Justice

70tration be properly understood and the value of their interaction be fully recognized.

Two other issues raised by you also deserve attention. direct election of the main institutions of a society can hardly be regarded as a significant democratic principle. in the united States of America, for example, the

president is elected by an electoral college of individuals chosen in state elections. in some other countries the president is elected by the parliament, not by the people. however, whether direct election is a democratic principle or not, it cannot be applied in the bahá'í faith because it is stated in the three-stage election and National Spiritual Assemblies must be the outcome of a two-stage election.

finally, there is the question of the membership of the universal house of justice being restricted to men. This, likewise, is a provision of the Sacred writings, as stated clearly by both 'Abdu'l-bahá and the guardian. it should

352 be viewed in the light of the principle mentioned above, that election to in-stitutions
of bahá'í administration is regarded as a summons to service and
353 not as an accession to power. it is also significant that the universal house
354 of justice has itself written that the fact that its membership is restricted
355 to men cannot be used as an indication that men excel women or that the bahá'í
principle of the equality of the sexes is not valid. As you know, it is
356 of the equality of men and women, and you are undoubtedly aware of the vigor with
which the bahá'ís are putting this into effect. This matter was
357 discussed at some length in a letter written on 31 may 1988 to the National
358 Spiritual Assembly of the bahá'ís of New zealand, a copy of which is en-
359 closed for your information.
360 The house of justice hopes that these comments will help you to resolve
361 the confusion which you indicate is troubling you.
362 with loving b ahá'í greetings,

for Department of tHe secretariat337 .15

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**Message to the International Bahá'í Youth Conference
in Karachi, Pakistan**

[signed: The Universal House of Justice]